Mahatma Gandhi University, Kottayam
Fifth Semester – MG5DSEFSQA00: Railway Food Service System
Regular Examination – October 2026

Part A – Multiple-Choice Questions

Q. No.	Correct answer	Answer
1	d	Organizing
2	a	Operating budget
3	b	Perishable food items
4	a	Monitoring food waste regularly
5	a	Railway passengers
6	c	Ensuring compliance with hygiene and quality standards
7	c	Planetary mixer
8	a	Separating raw and cooked foods
9	a	Braising
10	d	Reducing cost while maintaining food quality
11	c	Shelf life and ease of service
12	a	Maintaining personal, equipment and environmental hygiene
13	d	Regular monitoring, inspection and corrective actions
14	c	Preventing further consumption and contamination
15	b	Wash, rinse, sanitize and air dry before use
16	c	Diarrhoea
17	b	Preventing cross-contamination between food items
18	c	Treating all passengers with courtesy and respect
19	c	Listening carefully and offering appropriate solutions
20	d	Responding politely and taking corrective action

Part B – Short Answer Questions

21. Methods used for maintaining inventory records in railway food service operations

- Stock registers: Record the quantity of food items received, issued and remaining.
- Bin cards: Track the movement and balance of individual items in storage.
- Purchase and issue records: Maintain details of purchased ingredients and items issued to the kitchen.
- Stock verification: Conduct regular physical checks and compare actual stock with recorded stock.
- FIFO/FEFO: Use First-In, First-Out or First-Expired, First-Out to manage stock and reduce spoilage.
- Digital inventory systems: Use computerized records to monitor stock levels, expiry dates and reorder requirements.

22. Different food preservation methods used in railway catering

- Refrigeration: Slows microbial growth and extends the storage life of perishable foods.
- Freezing: Preserves foods by lowering their temperature and restricting microbial growth.
- Heat treatment: Cooking and pasteurization destroy many harmful microorganisms.
- Canning: Uses heat processing and airtight packaging to preserve suitable foods.
- Dehydration: Removes moisture to reduce microbial growth.
- Chemical preservation: Approved preservatives help control spoilage in suitable food products.
- Packaging: Airtight and appropriate food-grade packaging protects food from contamination.

23. Factors affecting food safety standards in railway food service units

- Personal hygiene and health of food handlers.
- Quality and safety of raw materials.
- Proper cooking and temperature control.
- Safe storage and transportation of food.
- Regular cleaning and sanitization of equipment.
- Prevention of cross-contamination.
- Safe water supply and proper waste disposal.
- Pest control and maintenance of food preparation areas.
- Staff training and compliance with food safety regulations.

24. Strategies to improve railway food service based on passenger feedback and preferences

- Collect feedback through surveys, complaint registers and digital platforms.
- Analyse passenger preferences and common complaints.
- Improve food taste, freshness, quality and portion size.
- Provide menu variety, including suitable dietary options.
- Maintain reasonable prices and transparent billing.
- Improve punctuality and efficiency of food delivery.
- Train staff in communication and customer service.
- Take corrective action and review passenger satisfaction regularly.

25. Different types of food service operations available in railways

- Pantry car service: Food is prepared or handled in designated onboard facilities and served to passengers.
- Onboard catering: Meals and refreshments are supplied directly to passengers during the journey.
- E-catering: Passengers order food through digital platforms for delivery at designated stations.
- Station food outlets: Restaurants, food courts and stalls provide meals and snacks.
- Refreshment rooms: Provide food and beverages to passengers at railway stations.

- Packaged food service: Ready-to-eat meals, snacks and beverages are supplied for convenient consumption.

26. Importance of cleaning and sanitation of food production equipment

- Removes food residues, grease and dirt.
- Reduces harmful microorganisms and the risk of foodborne illness.
- Prevents cross-contamination between raw and cooked foods.
- Maintains food quality and prevents undesirable odours.
- Extends the useful life of equipment.
- Supports compliance with hygiene standards.
- Improves workplace safety and operational efficiency.

27. Major functions performed by IRCTC in railway catering and hospitality services

- Organizes and manages railway catering services.
- Provides catering through onboard and station-based facilities.
- Facilitates e-catering and online food ordering.
- Monitors food quality, hygiene and service standards.
- Coordinates with catering service providers and vendors.
- Addresses passenger complaints and feedback.
- Supports hospitality services, including tourism-related services.
- Works to improve passenger convenience and service quality.

28. Factors influencing effective service standards in railway food service operations

- Food quality, taste, freshness and presentation.
- Compliance with food safety and hygiene requirements.
- Timely preparation and delivery of meals.
- Courteous and well-trained staff.
- Accurate orders and transparent billing.
- Availability of adequate stock and equipment.
- Efficient management of time and resources.
- Passenger feedback and complaint resolution.
- Regular supervision and performance evaluation.

Part C – Essay Questions

29. Procedures for handling customer complaints in railway catering services

1. Identification of complaints

- Listen carefully to the passenger's concern.
- Identify the nature of the complaint, such as poor food quality, delay, incorrect orders or overcharging.
- Record relevant details, including the time, order and location.

2. Acknowledgement

- Respond promptly and politely.
- Allow the passenger to explain the issue.
- Express concern and apologize when appropriate.

3. Investigation

- Verify the complaint and check the order or bill.
- Inspect the food or service involved.
- Consult the concerned staff and identify the cause.

4. Resolution

- Replace unsuitable or incorrect food where appropriate.
- Correct billing errors or arrange refunds according to policy.
- Provide an alternative solution when necessary.
- Escalate serious food safety issues to the responsible authority.

5. Documentation

- Record the complaint, investigation, action taken and outcome.
- Maintain records for future review.

6. Follow-up

- Confirm whether the issue has been resolved satisfactorily.
- Identify recurring problems.
- Implement corrective and preventive measures.

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30. Procedures for monitoring and maintaining food safety standards in railway food service operations

1. Inspection of raw materials

- Purchase ingredients from reliable and approved suppliers.
- Check freshness, quality, packaging and expiry dates.
- Reject spoiled or contaminated materials.

2. Personal hygiene

- Ensure food handlers wash their hands properly.
- Maintain clean uniforms and appropriate protective clothing.
- Restrict ill food handlers from food-handling duties when necessary.

3. Cleaning and sanitation

- Clean food-contact surfaces and utensils regularly.
- Wash, rinse, sanitize and air-dry equipment appropriately.
- Maintain cleaning schedules and records.

4. Temperature control

- Cook foods adequately.
- Maintain appropriate hot-holding and cold-storage temperatures.
- Monitor and record temperatures during storage, preparation and service.

5. Prevention of cross-contamination

- Separate raw and cooked foods.
- Use appropriate utensils and cutting boards.
- Store food in clean, covered and suitable containers.

6. Safe storage and transportation

- Maintain the required storage conditions.
- Protect food during transport and onboard service.
- Follow FIFO/FEFO stock rotation practices.

7. Water supply and waste management

- Use safe water for food preparation and cleaning.
- Dispose of waste promptly.
- Maintain effective pest-control measures.

8. Monitoring and documentation

- Conduct regular inspections and food safety checks.
- Maintain temperature, cleaning and stock records.
- Identify deviations and take corrective action.

9. Training and compliance

- Train employees in food hygiene and safe food handling.
- Follow applicable food safety regulations and railway catering requirements.

31. Organizational structure of railway food service units and the role of different levels of management

1. Top-level management

- Establishes policies, objectives and service standards.
- Allocates budgets and resources.
- Ensures compliance with applicable regulations.
- Reviews overall performance and passenger satisfaction.

2. Catering managers

- Plan menus and coordinate food service activities.
- Manage purchasing, inventory and staffing.
- Supervise service providers and operational performance.
- Address operational problems and monitor costs.

3. Supervisors

- Monitor daily kitchen and service operations.
- Check food quality, hygiene and staff performance.
- Ensure proper storage and stock handling.
- Coordinate preparation and timely delivery of meals.

4. Kitchen staff and cooks

- Prepare food according to standard recipes.
- Maintain cleanliness and safe food-handling practices.
- Follow cooking and portion-control procedures.
- Minimize food wastage.

5. Service staff

- Take and deliver orders.
- Serve passengers courteously.
- Maintain service areas and handle routine requests.
- Report complaints and service problems.

6. Storekeepers and purchasing staff

- Procure and receive ingredients.
- Maintain stock registers and inventory records.
- Check expiry dates and storage conditions.
- Issue materials according to requirements.

7. Quality and food safety personnel

- Inspect food quality and hygiene.
- Monitor compliance with food safety procedures.
- Maintain inspection records.
- Recommend corrective measures.

Importance of proper organization

- Defines duties and responsibilities.
- Improves communication and coordination.
- Supports cost control and efficient resource use.
- Promotes hygiene and consistent food quality.
- Improves accountability and passenger satisfaction.

32. Different cooking methods used in railway catering

Cooking methods are classified into moist-heat, dry-heat and combination methods.

1. Moist-heat cooking methods

These methods use water, steam or another aqueous liquid to transfer heat.

- Boiling: Food is cooked in water at its boiling point. Example: rice, eggs and vegetables.
- Simmering: Food is cooked gently in liquid below the boiling point. Example: soups and gravies.
- Steaming: Food is cooked using steam. Example: idli and steamed vegetables.
- Poaching: Food is cooked gently in liquid at a relatively low temperature. Example: eggs.
- Blanching: Food is briefly treated with boiling water or steam before further processing.

Advantages: Moist-heat methods can produce tender foods and are useful for preparing large quantities.

2. Dry-heat cooking methods

These methods use hot air, hot surfaces, fat or direct radiant heat.

- Baking: Food is cooked using hot air in an oven. Example: bread and cakes.
- Roasting: Food is cooked using dry heat. Example: roasted meat and vegetables.
- Grilling: Food is cooked using direct heat from above or below. Example: grilled chicken.
- Shallow frying: Food is cooked in a small quantity of oil.
- Deep frying: Food is immersed in hot oil. Example: samosas and cutlets.
- Sautéing: Food is cooked quickly in a small amount of fat.

Advantages: Dry-heat methods can produce desirable browning, crispness, flavour and texture.

3. Combination cooking methods

These methods combine dry heat and moist heat.

- Braising: Food is first browned and then cooked slowly with a small quantity of liquid. Example: braised meat.

- Stewing: Small pieces of food are cooked slowly in liquid. Example: meat stew.
- Pot roasting: Food is initially browned and then cooked in a covered vessel with limited liquid.

Advantages: Combination methods improve tenderness, develop flavour and are suitable for preparing many meat and vegetable dishes.

4. Factors affecting the selection of cooking methods

- Type and quantity of food.
- Desired taste, texture and appearance.
- Nutritional quality.
- Available equipment and fuel.
- Preparation time and service schedule.
- Cost and energy efficiency.
- Food safety requirements.
- Suitability for bulk preparation and transportation.